who believes that the Vedas contain self-evident and axiomatic truths',[4] thus seeking to create a religious identity, based on sacred texts, that would be eligible for special consideration from a British colonial regime that had already extended recognition to Muslims (as members of a defined religious community following the dictates of the Quran). Two decades later Mahatma Gandhi added to Tilak's basic view, writing that Hindus are people who believe in the Vedas, the Upanishads, the multiple Hindu scriptures, the various incarnations of God, rebirth or reincarnation, *varna* (caste) and *ashrama* (the four stages of life, which I describe later), and veneration and protection of the cow, and do not express disbelief in idol worship. This is a rather long and contentious list, since many Hindus (myself included) do not subscribe to some of these requirements and do not consider themselves any less Hindu for not doing so. The foundational theorist of the political philosophy of Hindutva, V. D. Savarkar (whose ideas are discussed more fully below), asserted in the 1920s that one could be a Hindu even if one did not recognise the religious authority of the Vedas.[5] To him, the various religious disputes within Hindu religious thought—between monism and pantheism, between Dvaita and Advaita, between the Vedas and the Upanishads and even including agnosticism and atheism—were irrelevant to the issue of Hindu identity. Savarkar saw 'Hindu-ness' or 'Hindutva' as opposed to 'Hinduism' as a uniting cultural construct that underlay the identity of all those who belong to 'Bharatvarsha', the ancient land of India. Unsurprisingly, then, India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, observed that 'Being a Hindu means all things to all men'.[6] British civil servant and historian Sir Alfred Lyall described Hinduism as a 'tangled jungle' full of paradoxes and contradictions, 'a religious chaos' spread all over India, difficult to comprehend and define. No wonder Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan began his celebrated 1926 Upton Lectures on Hinduism by asking of his own faith: 'Is it a museum of beliefs, a medley of rites, or a mere map, a geographical expression?'.[7]

As I have argued, one corollary of this eclecticism is the willingness of Hindus to accept other faiths and modes of worship—indeed often embrace them for themselves. It is quite common for Hindus to show